Dream Kingdom

Book 1: The Dream Kingdom
Chapter 1: The Analog Jammer – Friday, October 30, 1992
Scene 1: Untitled Chapter
Scene 2: Untitled Chapter
Scene 3: Untitled Chapter
Chapter 2: The Ghost in the Dark – Saturday, October 31, 1992
Scene 1: Untitled Chapter
Scene 2: Untitled Chapter
Scene 3: Untitled Chapter

Book 1: The Dream Kingdom

Chapter 1: The Analog Jammer – Friday, October 30, 1992

Scene 1: Untitled Chapter

Date: 1992-10-30 at 23:42

Ocea shifted her weight on the unforgiving wooden slats of the tiny cot, her shoulder pressing against the rough, heavy fabric of Tayâ€™s drab grey tunic. The basement closet was a windowless, suffocating box, smelling of ozone, damp stone, and the metallic tang of obsolete magical tech piled haphazardly on the floor. A gutted, heavy scrying terminal sat in the corner, its cracked glass screen staring blankly at them, a graveyard of multicolored wires spilling from its beige casing.

She looked up at her brother. Before the CRT television back in their living room had swallowed them whole, Tay had always been the warm center of her universeâ€”the older brother who gave the best, breathless bear hugs and never pushed her away. Now, his jaw was clenched, his eyes locked with terrifying intensity onto a parchment scroll radiating a sickly, glowing purple light. The dark magic washed over his face, making him look pale, hollow, and frighteningly unfamiliar. He was right beside her, forced into this cramped, shared space to hide her from a world he believed wanted her dead, yet he felt miles away.

Ocea leaned in, her cheek lightly brushing his rigid arm. She craved the safety of his embrace, trying to bridge the gap with the same familiar, physical affection they used to share. Instead, a freezing numbness radiated from his corrupted form, an icy wall built by the Grand Wizardâ€™s manipulations. She knew, beneath that cold

grey tunic, rested his jagged, ocean-blue half of their clay summer-camp medallion, secretly grieving for the sister who was sitting right beside him. Her fingers brushed her own pocket, feeling the reassuring, grounded weight of her fire-engine red half.

“You’re doing great, Tay,” Ocea whispered, playing the part of the smug, supportive sibling.

She pressed closer, using the movement to mask the faint, warm shimmer building in her palm. With a subtle flick of her fingers, she let a stream of golden “pixel” magic slip into the unraveling parchment of his scroll. The golden data wove silently into the dark purple runes, corrupting his cursed assignments with quiet sabotage. He couldn’t commit true evil. She simply wouldn’t let him.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

The sudden, earth-shaking rhythm of heavy footsteps echoed through the dungeon hallway outside their door. Oceaâ€™s heart slammed against her ribs.

Tay stiffened instantly, the scroll snapping shut in his hands. The heavy iron hinges of the thick oak door began to hum, emitting a searing, violent crimson glow. The Grand Wizard was here.

“Hide,” Tay hissed, his voice tight with panic.

Ocea didn’t hesitate. She threw herself off the cot, scrambling desperately across the cold stone floor and wedging herself tightly behind a towering stack of cardboard boxes and cracked magical hardware. She curled into a ball, pressing her back against the gutted scrying terminal, praying its ambient static would act as an analog jammer to mask the golden glow of her magic before the door swung open.

Scene 2: Untitled Chapter

Date: 1992-10-30 at 23:45

Ocea clamped her hands over her mouth, her knees pressed hard against her chest behind the cracked beige casing of the scrying terminal. The heavy oak door didn’t just open; it exploded inward, the iron hinges groaning under the violent force of the Grand Wizard’s entry.

From the narrow gap between a cardboard box and a tangled spool of copper wiring, Ocea watched the towering, shadowy figure sweep into the claustrophobic room. The air instantly grew freezing and thick, smelling of ozone and burning sulfur.

“Show me your progress, apprentice,” the Wizardâ€™s voice boomed, a grating sound that vibrated right through the stone floor and into Oceaâ€™s bones. “I expect mastery, not mediocrity.”

Ocea saw Tay straighten his spine. The terrified, hollow boy from a moment ago vanished, replaced by a smug, arrogant henchman. Tay puffed out his chest, a smirk twisting his features in a way that made Ocea’s stomach churn.

“Watch and learn,” Tay boasted, his voice dropping an octave in a desperate bid to sound intimidating.

He unrolled the glowing purple scroll and began the incantation. Dark magic crackled around his fingertips, harsh and jaggedâ€”until a sudden, warm burst of golden pixel light sparked from the center of the parchment. The dark magic hissed, backfiring with a pathetic *pop* that sent a puff of harmless, glittering smoke into the air. Ocea smiled into her hands; her sabotage had worked perfectly.

The Grand Wizard scoffed, a sound dripping with venomous disappointment. “Pathetic. Your grief makes you sloppy, boy. You are inexperienced, weak, and entirely incapable of wielding true power. Do it again when you learn to focus.”

Without another word, the Wizard turned on his heel and swept out of the tiny room. The heavy oak door slammed shut with a concussive thud, leaving behind a terrifying, ringing silence.

Ocea waited for the crimson glow to fade from the iron hinges before she pushed the heavy boxes aside and crawled out from her hiding spot. She dusted the ambient static and cobwebs from her blue dress.

Tay was staring at his hands, his shoulders slumped. “This is what I have to put up with,” he muttered, his voice trembling with a mix of shame and residual dark energy.

Oceaâ€™s heart broke. She stepped forward and reached out, wrapping her arms tightly around his waist and pressing her cheek against the rough grey fabric of his tunic. *I’m right here,* she wanted to broadcast through the hug. *I love you.*

But the warmth she expected never came. Tay didn’t push her away, but he didn’t lean in, either. He stood rigid, his arms hanging limply at his sides like heavy lead pipes. The coldness of his corruption seeped through his clothes, chilling her skin.

Ocea pulled back just enough to look up at his face, her eyes pooling with sad confusion. “Tay, you love my hugs,” she whispered softly. “What’s wrong?”

He stared blankly at the wall, his jaw working as he pondered the question. For a split second, Ocea thought she saw the old Tayâ€”the brother who used to spin her around in the living roomâ€”trying to fight his way to the surface.

Then, the dark purple magic flared in his eyes.

“Because the Wizard chose *me*, Ocea!” Tay exploded, his voice cracking like a whip in the confined space. “Me! Not you!”

Ocea flinched, stepping back. The words stung like a physical slap. In her entire life, across two different worlds, Tay had never snapped at her. Never. But beneath the twisted, brainwashed anger contorting his features, Ocea saw the micro-expressions of pure, agonizing pain. He didn’t mean it. The Wizard had twisted his profound grief into a toxic, defensive armor.

She swallowed the lump in her throat. Her mission was suddenly clearer than ever: she had to break him out of this dark spell, no matter what it took.

But not tonight. She glanced around the cramped, dungeon-like closet. The purple magical torches mounted on the stone walls were sputtering, their harsh light dimming into a low, exhausted ember. It was incredibly late, and the emotional toll hung heavy over them both.

Ocea reached out again, this time gently taking his rigid hand. “It’s late. Tay, come to bed.”

He looked at the tiny wooden cot, his brow furrowed defensively.

“Yes, I know it’s a small cot,” Ocea said, her voice dropping to a gentle, comforting murmur, echoing the normalcy of their life back in 1992. “But you like sleeping cuddled up with me.”

The anger in Tay’s eyes flickered, the dark purple dimming just a fraction as a wave of immense exhaustion washed over him. He looked down at her, the harshness melting into a quiet, terrified vulnerability.

“Yeah. You’re right,” Tay admitted softly, a faint echo of the older brother she remembered. He squeezed her hand, just barely, before glancing nervously at the heavy oak door. “But we can’t let him find you.”

Scene 3: Untitled Chapter

Date: 1992-10-30 at 23:55

The tiny wooden cot creaked in protest as they both climbed onto the thin, lumpy mattress. It was impossibly cramped, significantly narrower than the cozy bed they used to share back home in 1992 when thunderstorms rolled over their neighborhood. Forced to lie on her side, Ocea instinctively slid her arm around Tay’s waist, pressing her face against the rough, cold fabric of his grey henchman tunic.

She felt the immediate, violent flinch in his muscles. His spine went entirely rigid, his body language screaming the harsh, defensive distance the Grand Wizard had drilled into him. Yet, as the seconds ticked by in the suffocating silence of the dungeon closet, Tay didn’t pull away. He didn’t brush her arm off. Beneath the layers of manufactured malice, Ocea felt the frantic, uneven thumping of his heart. As her palm rested lightly near his chestâ€”right where she knew he kept his ocean-blue half of their clay medallion hiddenâ€”she sensed the agonizing war tearing him apart.

It washed over her with sudden, terrifying clarity. He wasn’t just being mean; he was trapped. The Grand Wizard’s dark magic hadn’t erased Tay’s love; it had weaponized his grief, locking his true self inside a twisted, psychological prison of his own mind. He desperately wanted the comfort of his little sister, but the corrupted programming wouldn’t allow him to fully accept it.

With a quiet, exhausted hiss, the sputtering purple torches mounted on the stone walls finally gave out, plunging the claustrophobic room into absolute, pitch-black darkness. Stripped of his sight, Ocea felt the tension in Tay’s shoulders waver.

In the safety of the total dark, Ocea spoke, her voice a soft, trembling whisper. “Why are you being like this?”

Tay remained perfectly still, though his breathing hitched.

“It’s me,” Ocea murmured, her small hand gently squeezing his side. “It’s your beloved Ocea. Tay, I know he’s hurting you. I can feel how cold you are. But where is the big brother who loves me? The one who spent hours sitting on the living room floor, patiently teaching me how to time my jumps in *Super Pixel Plumbers*? That’s the Tay I want right now.”

For a long, agonizing moment, there was only the sound of the ambient static humming from the dead scrying terminal across the room.

Then, Ocea felt it. The cold, unyielding armor of dark magic radiating from him seemed to subtly fracture. Under the cover of darkness, Tay let out a long, ragged, shuddering exhale that sounded dangerously close to a sob. He slowly lifted his hand, his fingers hesitating in the blackness, before he let them rest gently over Ocea’s small hand on his waist. It was a tiny, fleeting gesture, but beneath the corrupted ice of the Grand Wizard’s spell, Ocea felt the unmistakable warmth of her older brother trying to break free.

Chapter 2: The Ghost in the Dark – Saturday, October 31, 1992

Scene 1: Untitled Chapter

Date: 1992-10-31 at 00:03

The darkness of the basement closet was absolute, heavy and suffocating. Ocea lay perfectly still on her side, her arm still draped cautiously across her older brotherâ€™s waist. Though the sputtering purple torches had died, the room was anything but peaceful. Beneath the rough grey fabric of his tunic, Tay was vibrating.

It wasnâ€™t the crackling, jagged energy of the dark magic this time. It was a violent, involuntary tremor that shook the narrow wooden frame of the cot. He was terrified.

Ocea pressed her forehead lightly against his shoulder, listening to his ragged, shallow breathing. Every creak of the ancient stone walls, every faint drip of condensation from the dungeon ceiling made him flinch. The puzzle pieces rapidly snapped together in her mind. His arrogance during the inspection, the forced cruelty, the desperate need to master the corrupted spellworkâ€”it wasn’t just brainwashing. It was a performance fueled by sheer, paralyzing terror. Tay was wide awake, waiting for the heavy oak door to explode inward again for a midnight inspection.

“Tay,” she breathed into the pitch-black space between them, her voice barely louder than the ambient static humming from the dead scrying terminal across the room. “It’s okay. I’m right here.”

He squeezed his eyes shut, his jaw clenched so tightly she could hear his teeth grinding.

“We’re going to get out of this,” Ocea whispered softly, rubbing her thumb in a slow, soothing circle against his side, trying to project every ounce of warmth she possessed into his freezing core. “I promise you. We’ll beat him, and we’ll somehow find our way back home. Back to our living room.”

Tay let out a sharp, choked gasp, his hand tightening agonizingly over hers. “You don’t understand,” he whispered back, his voice cracking with the unbearable weight of a secret he had carried alone. “He can’t find you. If he comes back in… Ocea, if he sees you…”

“He won’t,” she promised, though her own heart began to hammer against her ribs.

“As far as the Wizard is concerned,” Tay continued, his words spilling out in a frantic, broken rush in the dark, “you are dead. You’re supposed to be dead right now.”

The words hung in the suffocating air, chilling Ocea to the bone. The Grand Wizard hadn’t just kidnapped them; he had fabricated her murder to shatter her brother’s mind and weaponize his grief. Tay wasn’t just hiding a trespasser in his tiny room. He was hiding a ghost that could expose the Wizard’s entire web of lies.

Ocea pulled him a fraction of an inch closer on the cramped mattress. She finally understood the magnitude of the danger they were in. She was supposed to be a corpse, a tragic memory used to fuel Tay’s dark magic. Remaining aliveâ€”and keeping him tethered to the lightâ€”was the most dangerous rebellion in the entire Dream Kingdom.

Scene 2: Untitled Chapter

Date: 1992-10-31 at 00:15

“I can’t sleep in this,” Ocea whispered into the suffocating darkness, shifting uncomfortably on the narrow mattress.

The stolen tunic was driving her crazy. She had swiped the coarse, ill-fitting garment off a clothesline during her perilous trek across the Dream Kingdom to find the lair, and the rough wool scratched her skin like sandpaper. Beside her, she knew Tay was equally miserable. His tunicâ€”issued directly by the Grand Wizardâ€”was heavier, woven from a drab, oppressive fabric that seemed to actively absorb the freezing dungeon air and drag down his shoulders. Neither of them had nightclothes; they only had the outfits they were wearing the day they were sucked through the television.

Back in their house, getting ready for bed was a chaotic but comfortable routine of taking turns, knocking on the door, and arguing over who used all the hot water. Here, the concept of privacy simply didn’t exist. The basement closet was brutally utilitarian, designed specifically to house a single, isolated servant. There was no bathroom. The only facility was in the far corner of the room: a simple, open wooden seat built directly over a fast-running underground stream that cut through the stone floor.

Handling the mundane necessities of life in a single-person cell required a silent, immediate sibling agreement.

“Turn around,” Ocea murmured gently. She slipped out from under his arm, suppressing a shiver as her bare feet hit the freezing stone floor.

She heard the immediate rustle of the mattress as Tay rolled over, pressing his face firmly into the cinderblock wall and covering his ears with his hands. It was a small, fiercely protective gesture of respect that bypassed the Wizardâ€™s dark corruption entirely, reminding her so intensely of the brother he used to be.

The roar of the rushing water rushing beneath the stone masked any sound, but Ocea hurried anyway, the heavy awkwardness of the claustrophobic space pressing in on her. The dark fantasy world mechanics were a cruel departure from the comforts of their 1992 reality. Once she was finished, she reached for the stolen tunic, but hesitated. It felt wrong to sleep in it. It felt like wearing the enemy’s armor.

Instead, she fumbled blindly in the dark for her satchel, her fingers finding the familiar, worn denim of her jeans and the soft cotton of her own t-shirt. Pulling her real-world clothes over her head felt like putting on a shield of normalcy, a desperate tether to who she really was.

“Okay,” Ocea whispered, turning away from the corner and pressing her own hands firmly over her ears. “Your turn.”

She faced the heavy oak door, her heart still beating a little faster at the thought of the glowing iron hinges, and waited. She could faintly hear the sounds of Tay moving behind her, the heavy rustle of the Grand Wizard’s issued uniform hitting the floor. She knew Tay had to hate his tunic even more than she hated hers. It wasn’t just uncomfortable; it was a physical manifestation of his servitude, a uniform he was forced to wear every single day to prove his loyalty to the monster who had lied to him.

A few moments later, Tay gently tapped her shoulder in the pitch black.

Ocea lowered her hands and turned around. Even without the sputtering purple torches, she could sense the subtle, microscopic shift in his posture. Tay had also changed into his own t-shirt and jeans from home. Stripped of the Wizard’s heavy grey uniform, if only in the absolute privacy of the dark, the dark apprentice vanished. He was just a terrified teenager from 1992 again.

Tay shivered in the damp, freezing air of the dungeon closet, wrapping his arms tightly around his chest. Without a word, he climbed back onto the tiny cot, moving as close to the wall as he could to make room for her.

Scene 3: Untitled Chapter

Date: 1992-10-31 at 00:20

Ocea shifted again on the lumpy mattress, suppressing a frustrated groan. The heavy, stiff denim of her jeans immediately bunched up around her knees, the thick seams digging painfully into her skin. Beside her, Tay was equally restless, his legs twitching in the cramped space. Denim was meant for riding bikes and scraping knees on the asphalt back in 1992, not for sleeping on a wooden board in a dungeon.

She could feel his hesitation radiating in the pitch-black room. Ocea knew her brother well. On a humid summer night back home, he wouldn’t have thought twice about sleeping in just his boxers. But here, in this suffocating closet, he was

remaining stubbornly, uncomfortably fully clothed. He was enduring the stiff fabric because he was trying to be respectful of her, desperately trying to maintain some illusion of propriety when the Grand Wizard had already stripped them of all their privacy and dignity.

Truthfully, surrounded by glowing iron hinges and dark magic, Ocea couldnâ€™t care less about modesty. When you were supposed to be a dead ghost hiding from an evil sorcerer, embarrassment simply ceased to exist.

Yet, as the oppressive weight of the Dream Kingdom pressed in on her, Ocea realized she craved the structure of their old life. She needed to draw a line in the sand, a deliberate boundary to keep the terrifying chaos of this world from completely eroding who they were. Enforcing a sense of modesty wasn't about embarrassment anymore; it was a desperate anchor to their humanity, a rule she was choosing to set so they didn't feel like animals trapped in a cage. Plus, they needed to actually sleep if they were going to survive.

Ocea sat up slowly, the ancient cot creaking under her. "We can't sleep in jeans," she whispered into the dark. "It's miserable."

Tay let out a long, heavy exhale, the sound tinged with immense relief and lingering anxiety. "Yeah. I know. But…"

"Shirts stay on," Ocea declared firmly, laying down the law with the absolute authority of a little sister who had made up her mind. "But the jeans have to go."

It was a simple, practical compromise, grounded entirely in the mundane reality of their lives before the CRT television had ruined everything. They took turns facing the freezing stone wall again, the rustle of heavy denim filling the dark room.

When Ocea finally slid back down onto the mattress, wearing only her oversized, soft cotton t-shirt and her undergarments, the immediate relief was profound. Without the restrictive armor of the denim, she could actually breathe. Tay settled in beside her, similarly freed from his stiff pants, his breathing already beginning to slow and even out.

Ocea reached out in the dark, her hand finding his arm. She rested her head against his shoulder, finally comfortable enough to let her own exhaustion pull her under. The room was still a freezing, windowless prison, but for the first time since she had arrived in this nightmare, it felt just a little bit like home.